

LiveTimer

Instructor Guide

What is LiveTimer?

LiveTimer is a real-time classroom timer for virtual and in-person instruction. You set timers for breaks, labs, and activities from your instructor control panel. Your students see the countdown on their phones or on a projected screen. The timer follows the student — they scan a QR code and the countdown is on their phone, so they can walk away from their desk and still know when to come back.

Getting Access

Your LiveTimer administrator will create an account for you and provide your login credentials (a Login ID and a temporary password). Once you have those, follow the steps below.

Logging In

- 1 Open your web browser and go to:

<https://livetimer-classroomtimer.onrender.com/instructor>

- 2 Enter the **Login ID** and **password** provided by your administrator.
- 3 Click **Login**. You will be taken to the instructor control panel.

Tip: After your first login, the browser remembers you — you won't need to log in again unless you clear your browser data or use a different browser.

Your data lives in the cloud: Your timers, alarms, sequences, settings, and class code are stored on the server, not on your computer. You can log in from any browser on any device and everything will be there — your full timer library, alarm sets, and preferences follow your account wherever you go.

Changing Your Password

- 1 Click the **gear icon** in the top-right corner to open Settings.
- 2 Find the **Change Password** section. Enter your current password and your new password, then click **Change**.

Your Starter Kit

When your account is created, it comes pre-loaded with a set of starter timers in your library and starter alarms in your alarm set. These are configured by your administrator to give you a useful starting point.

These are yours — you can use them as-is, modify them to fit your class schedule, or delete any you don't need. You can also create new timers and alarms from scratch at any time. Think of the starters as suggestions, not requirements.

LiveTimer URLs

LiveTimer uses two main URLs. Understanding which is which will help you direct students correctly and avoid confusion.

Instructor URL

<https://livetimer-classroomtimer.onrender.com/instructor>

This is your control panel. Only instructors with a valid login can access it. This is where you set timers, manage your library, configure alarms, and monitor students. Never share this URL with students.

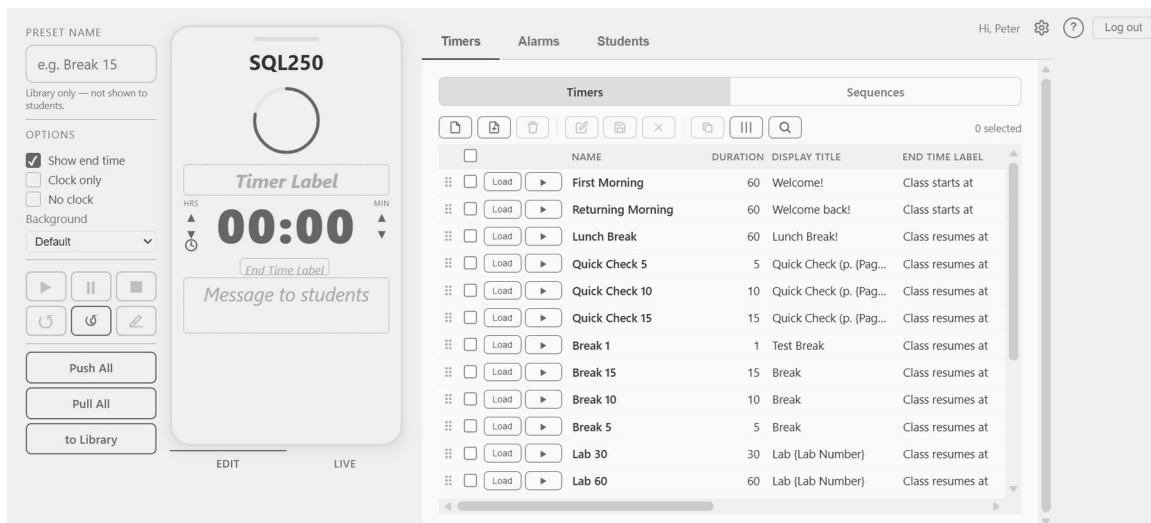
Student URL

<https://livetimer-classroomtimer.onrender.com/>

This is what students see. No login required — they just need the class code or QR code to connect. This is the URL embedded in QR codes and used for OBS browser sources. When students scan your QR code, they land here automatically with the class code pre-filled.

Tip: The only difference is the /instructor at the end. Without it, you get the student timer view. With it, you get the instructor control panel. If a student accidentally goes to the /instructor URL, they will see a login screen and cannot get past it without credentials.

The Instructor Panel



The instructor panel has two main areas side by side:

- **Left column** — A phone-shaped mockup that shows exactly what your students see. This is your live preview and your main editing surface.
- **Right column** — Tabs for Timers (your timer library and sequences), Alarms (time-of-day alerts), and Students (connections and check-in status).

Below the mockup you'll find an Edit / Live toggle. Edit mode lets you type directly on the mockup. Live mode shows an iframe of the actual student page — a pixel-perfect preview of what phones see, including check-in buttons.

Working with Timers

There are several ways to create and start a timer. The method you choose depends on how often you reuse the same timer settings.

Method 1: Quick Timer (Mockup)

The fastest way for a one-off timer. Type directly on the mockup:

- 1 Use the **hour/minute spinners** on either side of the clock digits to set the duration. Hold an arrow down to spin rapidly.
- 2 Click the **label** area below the clock to type a label (e.g., "Break").
- 3 Click **Play**. The timer starts on all connected phones immediately.

This works well for spontaneous timers, but for timers you use repeatedly, the library is more efficient.

Method 2: Timer Library (Recommended)

The Timers tab contains your saved timer presets — a collection of pre-configured timers you can start with one click. This is the recommended way to work with timers because it's fast and consistent.

- **Click a timer name** to load its settings onto the mockup (ready to review and start).
- **Click the play button** next to a timer to load AND start it immediately in one click.
- Create new library timers using the toolbar buttons (page icon for dialog, page-with-plus for inline).

Tip: You can also duplicate an existing timer — select it in the grid and click the Duplicate button (copy icon) on the toolbar. The copy appears with the same settings and a " (copy)" suffix on the name. Edit it from there.

Creating Timer Presets

There are three ways to add a new timer to your library:

From the mockup (To Library button)

Set up a timer on the mockup — duration, label, message, display options — then click the To Library button on the left panel. In the dialog that opens, select "Create New", give it a name, and click Create. The timer is saved to your library with all the settings exactly as they appear on the mockup. This is the most natural way to create a timer: build it visually, test it, then save it.

Inline mode (New Inline button)

Click the second toolbar button (page-with-plus icon) to add a blank row directly in the library grid. Type values into each cell — name, duration, title, message, etc. Click the Save button on the toolbar (or press Enter) when done. This is faster when you know exactly what you want and prefer to type directly into the grid.

Dialog mode (New button)

Click the first toolbar button (page icon) to open a form dialog. Fill in the name, duration, display title, end time label, message, and all options (show end time, background mode, clock only, no clock, after loading). Click Save. This is best when you want to configure every detail of a new timer from scratch.

Method 3: Duration Popup

Click the clock icon on the mockup (below the left spinner) to open the Duration Popup. This gives you:

- Larger hour/minute spinners
- **Quick-set buttons** for common durations (5, 10, 15, 30 minutes, etc.)

- **Target Time mode** — set an end time (e.g., "10:30 AM") and the duration is calculated automatically

Method 4: Sequences

Sequences let you chain multiple library timers together so they run one after another automatically. At the top of the Timers tab, toggle between Timers and Sequences views. Create a sequence by adding timers from your library in order, name it, and save. Click a sequence name to start — the first timer plays, and when it finishes, the next one loads automatically. A progress bar shows the current and next steps, with Skip and End buttons for manual control.

Variables in Timer Fields

Timer labels and messages can contain variables — words or phrases enclosed in curly braces like {Lab Number} or {Student Group?}. When you load a timer that contains variables, LiveTimer prompts you to fill in each one before the timer starts.

For example, if your timer label is:

Lab {Lab Number} — {Activity}

When you load this timer, two prompts appear — one asking for "Lab Number" and one asking for "Activity". If you type "3" and "Subnetting", the label becomes:

Lab 3 — Subnetting

This lets you create reusable timer templates. Instead of making separate timers for Lab 1, Lab 2, Lab 3, you make one timer with {Lab Number} and fill it in each time.

Variables work in both the Display Title and Message fields. If the same variable name appears in both fields, you are only prompted once and the value is used in both places. If you cancel any prompt, the timer load is cancelled.

Tip: Use descriptive variable names — your future self will thank you. {Lab Number} is clearer than {x}. The name inside the braces is exactly what appears in the prompt dialog.

Transport Controls

To the left of the phone mockup, you'll find four transport buttons:

- **Play** — Start the timer. All connected students see the countdown begin.
- **Pause** — Freeze the countdown. Students see it paused.
- **Stop** — End the timer completely. The clock resets to 00:00 and all text fields (except Course Title) are cleared. The alarm sound stops.
- **Restore** — After stopping, brings back the last timer with recalculated remaining time. Useful if you accidentally stop a running timer.

Stop vs. Restore: Stop is final — it zeroes the clock. But if you stopped by mistake, Restore recovers the timer and recalculates how much time was left based on the original end time. It's like an undo for Stop.

Adding Time to a Running Timer

If a timer is running and you need to give students more time:

- 1 Click the **clock icon** on the mockup to open the Duration Popup. The popup opens even while the timer is running.
- 2 Set the amount of time you want to add using the spinners or quick-set buttons.
- 3 Click the **+Add** button. The extra time is added to the running timer immediately. Students see the countdown jump.

Note: The +Add button adds time to the running timer. The Play button in the popup would replace the current timer with a new one.

Push and Pull

When you edit text on the mockup, your changes are local until you send them to students. This is where Push and Pull come in.

Push

Sends the text from the mockup field to all connected students. When you click a field on the mockup and type, students don't see the change yet — you're editing your local copy. Click Push (or Push All below the mockup) to send it live. The Play button also pushes all fields automatically before starting.

When to use Push: If you're preparing the next timer while the current one is running, you can type the new label and message without students seeing it. When the timer finishes and you're ready, Push All sends everything at once.

Pull

Does the opposite — loads the current student-visible value back into the mockup field. Use this when you want to see what students are currently seeing, or to undo a local edit that you haven't pushed yet.

Each editable field has its own Push, Pull, Clear, and Revert buttons that appear when you click on the field. There's also a Push All button on the left panel that pushes all fields at once.

Font Size Controls

Each text field on the mockup has small A- and A+ buttons in its toolbar. These control the font size on the student's phone, not just on the mockup. Click A+ to increase the font, A- to decrease it. The display between them shows the current scale (e.g., "120%") or "auto" when no override is set. Click the percentage to reset to auto.

Font overrides are reset when you click Stop, so each timer starts fresh.

Note: Font size changes are not WYSIWYG — different phones have different screen sizes and resolutions, so the same scale value will look different on each device. Use the controls to get the general size you want, but expect some variation from phone to phone.

To Library (Batch Updates)

The To Library button (on the left panel) lets you push settings from the mockup to multiple timers in your library at once. This is powerful when you need to make the same change across many timers — for example, switching all your timers to a black background, or updating the end time label on every timer.

How it works

Set the value you want on the mockup (e.g., select Black background in the options panel), then click To Library. A dialog opens with two modes:

- **Update Selected** — Apply specific fields from the mockup to timers you select from your library. Check the fields you want to update (you do not have to update all of them), select the timers to apply them to, and click Apply.
- **Create New** — Create a brand new timer in your library using the current mockup values. Give it a name and click Create.

The Fields panel

The left side of the dialog shows every field that can be pushed to the library. Each field has a checkbox and an editable control showing the current mockup value:

- **Duration** — Hours and minutes
- **Display Title** — The label students see below the countdown
- **End Time Label** — Text above the end time (e.g., "Back at")
- **Message** — Text at the bottom of the student view
- **Show End Time** — Whether to display the end time
- **Background** — Default, Transparent, or Black
- **Clock Only** — Display-only mode for projected screens
- **After Loading** — Which tab to switch to after loading the timer

Check only the fields you want to change. Unchecked fields are left untouched on the selected timers. You can also edit the values in the dialog before applying — you do not have to go back to the mockup.

The Timers panel

The right side shows your entire timer library with checkboxes. Use **Select All** to check every timer, or pick specific ones. A search bar lets you filter by name. Only checked timers receive the update.

Example: To switch all timers to black background, set Background to Black on the mockup, click To Library, check only the Background field on the left, click Select All on the right, and click Apply. Every timer in your library now has a black background — everything else is untouched.

Sharing the Timer with Students

Students connect by scanning a QR code or entering a 4-character class code on their phones.

- 1 Click the **Students** tab. You'll see your **class code** and a **QR code**.
- 2 Display the QR code on your projector, share your screen in Zoom, or use the dedicated QR display page for OBS.
- 3 Students scan the QR code with their phone camera. The timer opens in their browser — no app install needed. Alternatively, they can go to the LiveTimer URL and enter the 4-character code. Each instructor has their own class code. Your students only see your timer.

Student Monitoring

The Students tab shows how many phones are connected and lists each student by name. Enable Check-in buttons to let students report their status (Working, Done, Away). You'll see a real-time summary with color-coded counts. Enable Class progress on phones to let students tap the progress ring on their phone to see an anonymous breakdown of class status (proportional donut chart — no names or numbers, just proportions).

Disconnect All Phones generates a new class code and disconnects everyone. Students need to re-scan or re-enter the new code. Use this between classes.

Settings

Click the gear icon in the top-right corner to open Settings. Here's what you'll find:

Change Password

Enter your current and new password to change your login credentials.

Instructor Phone

Scan the QR code or copy the URL to connect your own phone to the timer without being counted as a student. Useful for monitoring the timer from your phone while teaching.

Color Palette

Choose from 13 color themes across four categories: Dark, Medium, Light, and Loud. Your choice is saved automatically. The palette only affects your instructor view — students always see the standard dark theme.

Alarm Sound

Select the sound that plays when a timer finishes. You can choose from built-in sounds or upload a custom .mp3 file. Enable Loop to repeat the sound until you stop it.

Warning Alert

A separate sound that plays a configurable number of minutes before the timer ends (e.g., a gentle chime 5 minutes before the break is over). Enable it, choose a sound, and set the minutes.

After Starting

Choose which tab to switch to automatically after starting a timer (Timers, Students, or Settings).

Student Updates (Mute)

When muted, timer changes only appear on your instructor panel — not on student screens. Useful for testing or preparing without disrupting students.

Library Backup

Export saves your entire timer library as a JSON file. Import loads a previously exported library. Use this for backup or to transfer your timers to another instructor account.

OBS URLs

Pre-built URLs you can copy and paste into OBS Studio as browser sources:

- **Timer URL** — Shows the student countdown view. Use as a browser source in OBS to display the timer on your stream or projected screen.
- **Timer URL with ?obs=true** — Same as above but skips the code entry gate and identifies as a display viewer. Respects Transparent and Clock Only modes.
- **QR-Only URL** — A dedicated page showing only the QR code, class code, and connection instructions. Use as a browser source in an OBS scene where students need to connect.

OBS Tip: In each browser source's properties, enable "Refresh browser when scene becomes active" so the timer reloads after updates. Set dimensions to match your display size for crisp text.

Software Updates

LiveTimer updates automatically. When an improvement or fix is ready, it's pushed out to everyone at once — there's nothing to install, and no version for you to choose or opt out of. The next time you open the instructor panel, you're already on the latest version.

Because updates arrive on their own, the app may occasionally look or behave a little differently than you remember. If you notice something has changed, check the update log to see what's new.

A red dot on the Settings gear (⚙️) means there's an update you haven't read yet. Open **Settings → About → What's New** to read the full list of changes; the dot clears once you've viewed it. Most updates just show the dot. Once in a while an important change will open the What's New list for you automatically — but never while a timer is running, so it won't interrupt your class. It waits until the timer stops.

Display Modes

Each timer in the library can have display modes saved with it. These affect only projected screens and OBS sources — never student phones:

- **Show End Time** — Displays the clock time the timer will end (e.g., "Back at 10:45 AM"). Helpful for breaks.
- **Clock Only** — Hides everything except the countdown digits on displays. Phones still show the full view.
- **Transparent** — Makes the background transparent on displays, useful for overlaying the timer on slides or camera feeds in OBS.
- **Black Background** — Solid black background on displays.

Clock Only and Transparent can be combined for a minimal, floating-digits overlay.

Alarms

Alarms are time-of-day alerts that fire at a specific clock time (e.g., 10:30 AM). Unlike timers, which count down a duration, alarms trigger at an absolute time. They're for class start/end times, mandatory breaks, or any schedule-driven event.

Each alarm has: a name, a time (with AM/PM), a sound, optional visual flash, optional repeat, and day-of-week scheduling (S M T W T F S buttons — toggle days off for classes that don't meet every day). A master toggle at the top turns all alarms on or off at once.

Alarm Sets let you maintain separate groups of alarms for different classes or schedules. Switch between sets using the dropdown. Create, duplicate, rename, or delete sets as needed.

Need Help?

Click the ? button in the top bar of the instructor panel to open the built-in help guide. It covers every feature in detail and can be printed.

First-time tip: The server runs on a free hosting tier. If the page takes a few seconds to load on your first visit, that's normal — the server is waking up. Once active, everything runs in real time.